BUDGETS ARE UP. CONFIDENCE IS STILL LOW.

What the Q3 IPA Bellwether Report means for Q4.

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01 · MORE FIRMS RAISED BUDGETS

+14.3%

Net balance of firms raising budgets: 25.6% raised them in Q3, 11.3% cut them. The highest since Q2 2024, and a third rise in a row.

Source: IPA Bellwether Report, Q3 2026

02 · MAIN MEDIA AT A NINE-YEAR HIGH

+9.8%

Net balance for main media advertising budgets, up from +1.5% in Q2. All five subcategories grew, the first time since tracking began in Q1 2020.

Source: IPA Bellwether Report, Q3 2026

03 · STILL DOWNBEAT ON THE INDUSTRY

34.6%

of panellists were pessimistic about industry-wide financial prospects, more than twice the 14.3% who were optimistic. Net balance: -20.3%.

Source: IPA Bellwether Report, Q3 2026

04

MONEY IS MOVING BEFORE CONFIDENCE

Clients are raising budgets while still nervous. Agencies waiting for a calmer quarter will miss it. Show a measurable return on Q4 spend now.

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WHAT YOU NEED

THE WEEKLY AI BRIEFING FOR AGENCIES.

One email a week. Practical, sourced, no hype.

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